

Session 6: The Importance of the Body

Key Takeaways

- The first agreed-upon Corinthian slogan appears in 1 Corinthians 6:12 and gives insight into Corinthian thought about the physical body: "All things are lawful for me."
- Paul reminds the Corinthians that they are "in Christ" and, therefore, ought to be participating in Jesus' resurrected life.
- The Corinthians' belief that the things of this world will be destroyed in the future motivated them to think that what they did with their bodies was of little to no consequence.
- According to Paul, if someone is a Christian, sexual integrity is one of the primary, non-negotiable ways to respond to Jesus' love and grace.

Who Judges the Body?

Corinthian believers were taking one another to a secular court for judgment. This was probably more like vexatious litigation, making winning the case a matter of honor. Courts were notoriously corrupt and would favor the powerful.

This reminds us of Jesus' teachings in Matthew.

Matthew 5:25-26 NIV

²⁵ Settle matters quickly with your adversary who is taking you to court. Do it while you are still together on the way, or your adversary may hand you over to the judge, and the judge may hand you over to the officer, and you may be thrown into prison. ²⁶ Truly I tell you, you will not get out until you have paid the last penny.

Paul sarcastically says, "Is it possible that there is nobody among you wise enough to judge a dispute between believers?" (1 Cor. 6:5b)

Paul is really upset here and is having a dialogue with them. A number of commentators now see this as diatribal—an argument to persuade an opponent. This is signalled by the number of times he says "Do you not know?" (Greek: *ouk oidate*/οὐκ οἶδατε) in 1 Corinthians 6.

"Do you not know (οὐκ οἶδατε)?"

- "the saints will judge the world" (v. 2)
- "that we will judge angels" (v. 3)
- "the unrighteous will not inherit the kingdom of God" (v. 9)
- "that your bodies are members of Christ" (v. 15)
- "that one joined to a prostitute is one body with them" (v. 16)
- "that the body of you all is a temple of the Holy Spirit" (v. 19)

Corinthian Slogans

The first agreed upon slogan comes in this chapter. This gives us some insight into Corinthian thought. However, there is some debate over where the slogans start and stop.

1 Corinthians 6:12-13 NRSV

¹² “All things are lawful for me,” but not all things are beneficial. “All things are lawful for me,” but I will not be dominated by anything. ¹³ “Food is meant for the stomach and the stomach for food,” and God will destroy both one and the other.

NIV inserts “you say,” which is not in the text.

1 Corinthians 6:12-13 NIV

¹² “I have the right to do anything,” **you say**—but not everything is beneficial. “I have the right to do anything”—but I will not be mastered by anything. ¹³ **You say**, “Food for the stomach and the stomach for food, and God will destroy them both.”

Another proposed Corinthian slogan comes in [verse 18b](#). The Corinthians: “Every sin which a man may commit is outside the body.” Paul: “On the contrary, the immoral man sins against his own body.”

The Debate over 1 Corinthians 6:9

In [1 Corinthians 6:9-10](#), Paul reiterates the vice list from [chapter 5](#) as those who will not inherit the Kingdom of God. He repeats sexually immoral, idolaters, coveters, drunkards, verbal abusers, and swindlers. He adds adulterers, men who have sex with men, and thieves.

There is much debate about the terms that Paul uses here in [1 Corinthians 6:9](#).

- *μαλακοὶ* (Greek: *malakoi*)
- *ἀρσενικοῖται* (Greek: *arsenokoitai*—lying with a man)

Malakoi is not a term that is used exclusively for homosexual. It’s a pejorative term meaning “softies, effeminate.” So some see this as a reference to a male prostitute or a passive partner in a male sexual relationship.

Arsenokoitai is a compound word and literally means “male-bedders.” It is also used in [1 Timothy 1:10-11](#) right after a reference to slave traders, so it might be referring to coercive homosexual relations, but we don’t really know.

Wesley Hill notes that *arsenokoites* has a “strong verbal connection to the Septuagint renderings of both [Leviticus 18:22](#) and [20:13](#), where both halves of the compound are used” (Hill, 2016). Paul may have coined the term himself.

Some Translation Options

- NIV: men who have sex with men

- NASB: homosexuals, probably submissive and dominant partners
- NRSV: male prostitutes and sodomites
- The Message: focuses on abuse

1 Corinthians 6:9-11 The Message

Don't you realize that this is not the way to live? Unjust people who don't care about God will not be joining in his kingdom. Those who use and abuse each other, use and abuse sex, use and abuse the earth and everything in it, don't qualify as citizens in God's kingdom. A number of you know from experience what I'm talking about, for not so long ago you were on that list. Since then, you've been cleaned up and given a fresh start by Jesus, our Master, our Messiah, and by our God present in us, the Spirit.

Diverging Views

The ancient world was not like our world and lines fall in very different places. Jews, Greeks, and Romans had different views of homosexual relations between men.

"For Jews, including those who formed the Christian movement, same-sex relations were indications of the depravity of non-Jewish society."

Loader, William (2016). "Homosexuality and the Bible." [*Two Views on Homosexuality, the Bible, and the Church*](#). Zondervan. 32.

Greeks approved of same-sex male relations under 30. They were seen to strengthen bonds between males and could be part of a mentoring relationship.

"Roman law treated same-sex relations between citizens as a criminal offence, but tolerated it between a Roman citizen and someone inferior, like a slave or a foreigner. Romans sometimes deplored same-sex relations as a Greek disease and typically self-indulgent, to which Greeks responded by deploring the fact that Romans usually did not expect such relations to cease when a young man turned thirty."

Loader, William (2016). "Homosexuality and the Bible." [*Two Views on Homosexuality, The Bible, and the Church*](#). Zondervan. 31.

Today there are many divergent views.

1. Those who think that there is an unqualified ban on same-sex sexual relations then and now. Nothing has changed.
2. Those who think there was an unqualified ban on some same-sex relations and those rules do not apply now.
3. Those who think there was and still is an unqualified ban in Scripture in all same-sex relations but it's archaic to apply that now, so we should choose not to.
4. Those who think that Scripture bans abusive same-sex sexual relations and would not rule the same for loving, monogamous same-sex marriage.
5. Those who think that Scripture does not condemn same-sex loving relations.

It seems as though, in general, the Corinthians were working on the basis that the things of this world would be destroyed. Whereas what Paul is trying to impress upon them is that what we do in the body will stay with

us because we're going to be raised from the dead (1 Cor. 6:14) and our bodies belong to Christ (1 Cor. 6:15).

Recommended Resource

[*Two Views on Homosexuality, the Bible, and the Church*](#). Preston Sprinkle (ed.). Zondervan, 2016.

Reflection Question

According to Paul, why do our physical bodies matter? And what is one implication of this for daily life?